

Proposed river trail gives boaters access

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A plan to open a path that could stretch from the Point to Fairmont, W.Va., could give boaters on the Monongahela a duck's-eye view of the region's rich industrial heritage, along with access points every couple miles along the Mon.

More than 120 residents turned out Saturday at the Palisades in McKeesport to chip in their thoughts on plans for the Mon River Water Trail being coordinated by Friends of the Riverfront and a host of other nonprofit groups.

The groups are researching a plan to install access points along the river, about every two miles, according to John Stephen, executive director of Friends of the Riverfront.

That, they hope, will encourage people to take to kayaks and canoes, along with motorized boats, to trace the river's trail past sites such as the blast furnace at U.S. Steel's former Duquesne Works and barge piers and docking facilities in Glassport.

"The river tells quite a story," Stephen said. "From the river, you can see a lot of the infrastructure" from the region's industrial past. "You get a really unique perspective on the Pittsburgh region."

The initial phase of the project would cover a stretch of 12 to 15 miles from the walking dam in Braddock to the dam in Elizabeth, including the Mon's intersection with the Youghiogheny, Stephen said. He expected that boater access points in that area would be doubled from five to 10.

Long-term goals, Stephen said, involve extending the water trail the length of the river. A Morgantown, W.Va.-based group has organized the Upper Mon Water Trail and is planning a 60-mile stretch from Fairmont, W.Va., to Rice's Landing, Greene County. The Mon River Water Trail would connect with the Upper Mon Trail at Rice's Landing, Stephen said.

Access points include a ramp and boat racks for kayaks and canoes. Stephen said the groups also plan to add temporary slips to allow motorized boaters to stop at points along the river. The cost for building an access point is about \$10,000, Stephen said.

The group plans to map the Braddock pool by next spring and begin installing additional access points the next year, Stephen said.

The process of creating better access for local river users isn't quite as easy as it might sound, officials at the "River Dialogue" explained yesterday. Clearing the Mon Valley Trail will require the cooperation of residents, government and

the private interests that own most of the riverfront property, they said.

"Access to waterways is something that people naively believe exists widely, but rarely does," said Al Staat, executive director of the North American Water Trails, a national group formed in 1993 to help local planners create water trails in their communities. Staat was the keynote speaker yesterday.

Planners define a water trail as a "recreational waterway on a river which contains access to places of interest, communities and natural places."

But to Stephanie Craft, 10, of McKeesport, who attended the conference with her grandparents, it simply means a place where mother ducks can more safely breed their young.

"The ducks need a place to nest," Stephanie said.

Sporting an orange life preserver and freckles to match, Stephanie had another wish for the human and animal users of the Youghiogheny.

"I'd like the water to be cleaner so people can swim in there," Stephanie said.

According to test results shown yesterday, the water is fairly clean.

Kathy Knauer, an environmental scientist, reported that human and animal waste bacteria levels in the Mon are well within the acceptable range during dry spells, and only exceed acceptable standards briefly during periods of heavy rain.

Besides water quality, other concerns about the Braddock pool include the area's heavy industry, which still creates access problems and hazards for boaters.

But Tim Collins, a research fellow at Carnegie Mellon, believes a good mixed use can be achieved.

"It's being done all over the country at this point; diverse uses can coexist," Collins said.

Yesterday's event was co-sponsored by 3 Rivers 2nd Nature, a Carnegie Mellon University think tank, and the Pennsylvania Environmental Council.

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